

SMALL BUSINESS STARTUP WORKBOOK

From Idea to Launch in 90 Days

Step-by-Step Planning Guide for New Entrepreneurs

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BUSINESS IDEA VALIDATION CHECKLIST

Before investing time and money, validate your idea:

MY BUSINESS IDEA: _____

VALIDATION CHECKLIST:

- ☐ Does this solve a real problem people have?
- ☐ Are people currently paying for solutions to this problem?
- ☐ Can I describe my ideal customer in one sentence?
- ☐ Is the market large enough to sustain a business?
- ☐ Do I have skills/knowledge in this area (or can I learn)?
- ☐ Can I start this with \$5,000 or less?
- ☐ Can I test this idea before fully launching?
- ☐ Am I passionate enough to work on this for 5+ years?
- ☐ Is there room for differentiation from competitors?
- ☐ Can this generate income within 90 days?

QUICK VALIDATION TESTS:

1. Talk to 10 potential customers - would they pay for this?
2. Search for competitors (competition = demand exists!)
3. Create a simple landing page and measure interest
4. Offer the service manually before building anything
5. Pre-sell before you create the product

Results of my validation: _____

GO / PIVOT / STOP (circle one)

MARKET RESEARCH WORKSHEET

INDUSTRY OVERVIEW:

Industry: _____

Industry size (annual revenue): \$_____

Growth trend: Growing / Stable / Declining

Key trends affecting this industry:

1. _____

2. _____

TARGET MARKET:

Total addressable market (TAM): \$_____

Serviceable market (SAM): \$_____

My realistic target (SOM): \$_____

CUSTOMER RESEARCH (talk to real people!):

Biggest pain point: _____

Current solution they use: _____

What they hate about current solution: _____

Price they'd pay for better solution: \$_____

Where they look for solutions: _____

INDUSTRY BARRIERS TO ENTRY:

___ High startup costs ___ Licenses/regulations

___ Established competitors ___ Technical expertise

___ Network effects ___ Brand loyalty

My competitive advantage: _____

TARGET CUSTOMER AVATAR

Create a detailed profile of your IDEAL customer:

DEMOGRAPHICS:

Name (fictional): _____

Age: ____ Gender: ____ Location: _____

Income: \$_____ Education: _____

Job title: _____

Family status: _____

PSYCHOGRAPHICS:

Values: _____

Hobbies: _____

Fears: _____

Goals/Dreams: _____

Frustrations: _____

BUYING BEHAVIOR:

Where they shop: _____

How they research purchases: _____

What influences their decisions: _____

Budget range for my product/service: \$_____

How often they'd buy: _____

SOCIAL MEDIA:

Platforms used: _____

Accounts they follow: _____

Content they engage with: _____

COMPETITIVE ANALYSIS TEMPLATE

Analyze your top 3 competitors:

COMPETITOR 1: _____

Website: _____

Price range: \$ _____

Strengths: _____

Weaknesses: _____

Their customers say (reviews): _____

COMPETITOR 2: _____

Website: _____

Price range: \$ _____

Strengths: _____

Weaknesses: _____

Their customers say (reviews): _____

COMPETITOR 3: _____

Website: _____

Price range: \$ _____

Strengths: _____

Weaknesses: _____

Their customers say (reviews): _____

MY DIFFERENTIATION (why choose me over them):

BUSINESS MODEL CANVAS

Key Partners: Who do I need to work with?

Key Activities: What must I do daily to deliver value?

Key Resources: What do I need (tools, people, money)?

Value Proposition: What problem do I solve uniquely?

Customer Relationships: How do I acquire & keep customers?

Channels: How do customers find and buy from me?

Customer Segments: Who exactly am I serving?

Cost Structure: What are my main expenses?

Revenue Streams: How exactly do I make money?

REVENUE MODEL & STARTUP COSTS

REVENUE MODEL (how will money come in?):

__ Product sales (one-time) __ Subscription/recurring
__ Service fees __ Commissions/affiliate
__ Advertising __ Licensing/royalties
__ Freemium (free + paid upgrade)

My primary revenue stream: _____

Price point: \$_____

Sales needed monthly to cover costs: _____

Monthly revenue goal (month 3): \$_____

Monthly revenue goal (month 12): \$_____

STARTUP COSTS CALCULATOR:

Legal/registration fees: \$_____

Website/domain/hosting: \$_____

Equipment/tools: \$_____

Initial inventory: \$_____

Marketing/advertising: \$_____

Insurance: \$_____

Software/subscriptions: \$_____

Professional services: \$_____

Emergency fund (3 months): \$_____

TOTAL STARTUP COSTS: \$_____

LEGAL STRUCTURE & FUNDING OPTIONS

LEGAL STRUCTURE COMPARISON:

SOLE PROPRIETORSHIP: Simplest. You ARE the business.

Pros: Easy setup, low cost, full control

Cons: Personal liability, harder to get funding

LLC (Limited Liability Company): Most popular for small biz.

Pros: Liability protection, tax flexibility, credibility

Cons: State fees, some paperwork, varies by state

S-CORP: Best for higher income businesses.

Pros: Tax savings on self-employment tax, credibility

Cons: More complex, payroll required, strict rules

My choice: _____ Reason: _____

FUNDING OPTIONS:

___ Personal savings (bootstrapping)

___ Friends & family

___ Small business loan (SBA)

___ Business credit card

___ Crowdfunding (Kickstarter, Indiegogo)

___ Angel investors

___ Grants (SCORE, local programs)

___ Side hustle income while building

My funding plan: _____

Amount needed: \$ _____

BUSINESS NAME & BRAND IDENTITY

BUSINESS NAME BRAINSTORM:

Idea 1: _____ Available? Y/N

Idea 2: _____ Available? Y/N

Idea 3: _____ Available? Y/N

Idea 4: _____ Available? Y/N

Idea 5: _____ Available? Y/N

CHECK: Domain available? __ Social handles available? __

CHECK: Trademark search clear? __

MY FINAL BUSINESS NAME: _____

BRAND IDENTITY WORKSHEET:

Brand personality (3 words): _____

Brand voice (formal/casual/playful/professional): ____

Colors that represent my brand: _____

Tagline/slogan: _____

BRAND PROMISE:

We help [target customer] achieve [desired outcome]
by [how we do it differently].

MISSION STATEMENT:

MARKETING PLAN TEMPLATE

MARKETING CHANNELS (rank by priority):

- ___ Social media (which platforms: _____)
- ___ Content marketing (blog, YouTube, podcast)
- ___ Email marketing
- ___ Paid advertising (Google, Facebook, Instagram)
- ___ SEO (search engine optimization)
- ___ Networking & referrals
- ___ Partnerships & collaborations
- ___ Local community (events, flyers, local SEO)
- ___ PR & media features

MARKETING BUDGET (monthly): \$ _____

FIRST 90 DAYS MARKETING PRIORITIES:

Month 1: _____

Month 2: _____

Month 3: _____

CONTENT STRATEGY:

I will create [type] content on [platform] [frequency].

LEAD GENERATION:

Free offer/lead magnet: _____

How I'll capture emails: _____

Follow-up sequence: _____

SALES FUNNEL & SOCIAL MEDIA STRATEGY

SALES FUNNEL PLANNING:

AWARENESS (how people discover you):

INTEREST (how you capture attention):

DECISION (how you help them choose you):

ACTION (how they buy/sign up):

RETENTION (how you keep them coming back):

SOCIAL MEDIA STRATEGY:

Primary platform: _____ Post frequency: ____x/week

Secondary platform: _____ Post frequency: ____x/week

Content mix: ____% Educational ____% Entertaining ____% Promotional

DAILY SOCIAL MEDIA TASKS (15-30 min):

___ Post content ___ Reply to comments

___ Engage with others' posts ___ Check messages

___ Share stories/reels ___ Track analytics weekly

90-DAY LAUNCH TIMELINE

DAYS 1-30: FOUNDATION

Week 1: Validate idea, research market, choose legal structure

Week 2: Register business, get EIN, open bank account

Week 3: Build website/landing page, set up social media

Week 4: Create first offer, develop pricing strategy

DAYS 31-60: BUILD

Week 5: Create content, build email list

Week 6: Develop systems/processes, set up payment processing

Week 7: Beta test with 3-5 people, gather feedback

Week 8: Refine offer based on feedback, prep for launch

DAYS 61-90: LAUNCH

Week 9: Pre-launch buzz, email sequence, social media push

Week 10: LAUNCH! Open for business officially

Week 11: Gather testimonials, refine marketing

Week 12: Review KPIs, plan next quarter

MY LAUNCH DATE: ____/____/____

I will celebrate by: _____

WEEKLY ACTION PLANNER - WEEKS 1-3

WEEK 1:

Top 3 priorities:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Revenue this week: \$_____ Hours worked: _____

Biggest win: _____ Biggest challenge: _____

WEEK 2:

Top 3 priorities:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Revenue this week: \$_____ Hours worked: _____

Biggest win: _____ Biggest challenge: _____

WEEK 3:

Top 3 priorities:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Revenue this week: \$_____ Hours worked: _____

Biggest win: _____ Biggest challenge: _____

WEEKLY ACTION PLANNER - WEEKS 4-6

WEEK 4:

Top 3 priorities:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Revenue this week: \$_____ Hours worked: _____

Biggest win: _____ Biggest challenge: _____

WEEK 5:

Top 3 priorities:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Revenue this week: \$_____ Hours worked: _____

Biggest win: _____ Biggest challenge: _____

WEEK 6:

Top 3 priorities:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Revenue this week: \$_____ Hours worked: _____

Biggest win: _____ Biggest challenge: _____

WEEKLY ACTION PLANNER - WEEKS 7-9

WEEK 7:

Top 3 priorities:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Revenue this week: \$_____ Hours worked: _____

Biggest win: _____ Biggest challenge: _____

WEEK 8:

Top 3 priorities:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Revenue this week: \$_____ Hours worked: _____

Biggest win: _____ Biggest challenge: _____

WEEK 9:

Top 3 priorities:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Revenue this week: \$_____ Hours worked: _____

Biggest win: _____ Biggest challenge: _____

WEEKLY ACTION PLANNER - WEEKS 10-12

WEEK 10:

Top 3 priorities:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Revenue this week: \$_____ Hours worked: _____

Biggest win: _____ Biggest challenge: _____

WEEK 11:

Top 3 priorities:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Revenue this week: \$_____ Hours worked: _____

Biggest win: _____ Biggest challenge: _____

WEEK 12:

Top 3 priorities:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Revenue this week: \$_____ Hours worked: _____

Biggest win: _____ Biggest challenge: _____

FINANCIAL PROJECTIONS & KPI TRACKING

12-MONTH REVENUE PROJECTION:

Month 1: \$_____ Month 2: \$_____ Month 3: \$_____
Month 4: \$_____ Month 5: \$_____ Month 6: \$_____
Month 7: \$_____ Month 8: \$_____ Month 9: \$_____
Month 10: \$_____ Month 11: \$_____ Month 12: \$_____
YEAR 1 TOTAL: \$_____

KEY PERFORMANCE INDICATORS (KPIs):

Revenue KPIs:	Goal	Actual
Monthly revenue:	\$_____	\$_____
Avg transaction value:	\$_____	\$_____
Customer lifetime value:	\$_____	\$_____

Growth KPIs:

New customers/month: _____
Website visitors/month: _____
Email subscribers: _____
Social media followers: _____

Profitability:

Gross margin: _____ %
Monthly expenses: \$_____
Break-even point: \$_____/month

RESOURCES & NEXT STEPS

FREE RESOURCES FOR NEW BUSINESS OWNERS:

SCORE: Free business mentoring (score.org)

SBA: Small Business Administration (sba.gov)

IRS: Small Business Tax Center (irs.gov)

SBDC: Small Business Development Centers (local)

TOOLS TO GET STARTED:

Website: WordPress, Shopify, Squarespace, Wix

Email: Mailchimp, ConvertKit, MailerLite

Accounting: Wave (free), QuickBooks, FreshBooks

Social media scheduling: Buffer, Later, Hootsuite

Design: Canva (free), Adobe Express

Payment processing: Stripe, Square, PayPal

MY NEXT 5 ACTIONS (do these THIS WEEK):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Remember: Done is better than perfect.

Start messy. Refine later. The world needs your idea!